CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

FINANCIAL ANALYST IN THE AI ERA

Companies drown in data and starve for someone who can say what it means for money.

★ TL;DR — ~$104K median (BLS, $103,570, May 2025), growth +7%, ~29,500 openings a year. The gate is a bachelor's and modeling skill — there is no entry licence: FINRA licensing is post-hire, employer-sponsored, and only for some roles. The catch: AI is eating the junior task list (first-pass models, call summaries), so the apprenticeship is shorter and more competitive than the one your manager had. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

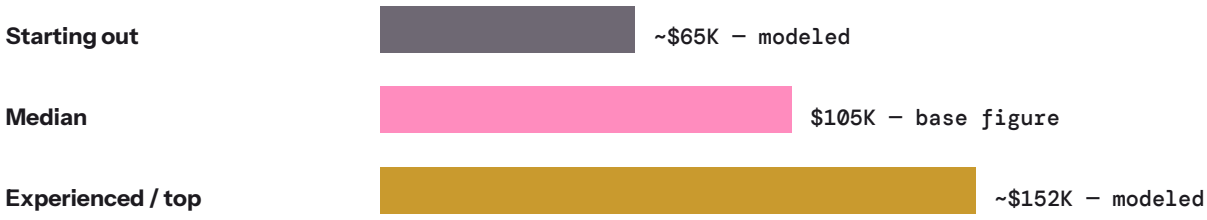
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$105K · TRAINING 2-4 years · AI RISK MEDIUM

- Every growing company eventually hires someone to own forecasts and budgets — and BLS still projects +7% after AI diffusion.
- The craft is modeling plus judgment: anyone can build a spreadsheet, few can defend one.
- Goldman Sachs leadership says AI now does the tedious early-years work — decks, models, call summaries — which raises the bar to conclusions, faster.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Financial Analyst is a ~$105K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A FINANCIAL ANALYST ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Build and maintain financial models and forecasts
- ✓ Track budgets vs actuals and explain the variances
- ✓ Analyze pricing, costs and investment proposals
- ✓ Present findings to managers who decide where money goes

Think: a weather forecaster for a company's money — models, probabilities, and people betting real budgets on your call.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
AI pulls data, builds first-pass models and writes variance summaries. OpenAI's Project Mercury hired 100+ former Wall Street analysts to train AI on model-building itself, and ChatGPT for Financial Services targets 'the research, financial modeling and pitchbook work entry-level analysts do'. Routine reporting packs that took a day now take an hour.	Assumptions are the job: which growth rate is honest, which cost is hiding, which project deserves funding. Executives want a person who stands behind a number.

⚠ **No licence will save you or gate you: FINRA licences require employer sponsorship, so 'get licensed first' courses are a detour — companies do not expect licences before you start (BLS). The real filter is the bachelor's plus demonstrable modeling. Quarter-end weeks are long.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Fully remote-capable analytical work ✓ Pay that reflects a scarce, verifiable skill ✓ A seat near real business decisions	✗ Deadline crunches around month- and quarter-end ✗ Your errors are measured in other people's money ✗ Advancement means owning harder questions, not fewer hours

Good fit? You love spreadsheets, think in scenarios, and can explain a model without hiding behind it.
Bad fit? You want quick entry, or you crumble when a senior leader challenges your numbers.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — FINANCE TEAM LADDER	DOOR B — BANKING / ADVISORY TRACK
Enter as a junior analyst in a company finance or FP&A; team. You inherit models, learn the business from its numbers, and grow into owning forecasts.	Start in banking, corporate development or an advisory firm, where modeling reps are intense. Harder entry, faster skill compounding — and any role-specific FINRA licence arrives sponsored, after the offer.

Smart move: Publish your modeling skill: rebuild a public company's forecast from its filings as a portfolio piece. A clean model is your audition.
Where you land after: Senior analyst, finance manager, then FP&A; leadership or strategy roles. Risk-specialist seats sit at the top of the pay range ($117,330 median).

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
BUILD THE	LEARN TO	BUILD THE	CONSIDER THE	GET ANALYST	OWN A

STEP 1 — Build the foundation

MONTHS 1-12

- Master accounting basics and Excel to an advanced level: lookups, pivots, scenario tables
- Learn how the three financial statements connect

STEP 2 — Learn to model

MONTHS 6-18

- Build full three-statement models and valuation models from scratch
- Redo each model until you can explain every assumption out loud

STEP 3 — Build the portfolio model

MONTHS 6-12

- Rebuild one public company's forecast from its filings, with a written thesis
- This is the audition piece you bring to interviews — it outranks certificates

STEP 4 — Consider the CFA — voluntarily

EXAM FEES · YEARS
1-3

- The CFA charter is voluntary and 'may enhance professional standing' (BLS) — start it for learning and signal, not because it's required
- Never pay for a 'licence' before a job exists: FINRA licences can't be held without a sponsoring employer

STEP 5 — Get analyst reps

PAID · YEARS 2-3

- Land a junior analyst seat or a finance internship-to-hire path; any role-specific licensing comes sponsored with the offer
- Own one recurring report end to end; make it better than you found it

STEP 6 — Own a forecast

WORKING · YEARS 3-4

- Take responsibility for a budget or forecast area
- Present to leadership and defend your assumptions — that's the promotion test

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- Today: read BLS's analyst page — bachelor's gate, no licence — then check five job posts for what they actually ask.
- Days 1–30: accounting foundations and serious Excel training underway.
- Days 31–60: first full model built from a real company's public filings.
- Days 61–90: portfolio model polished; applications out for junior and internship roles.
- Day 90: you're in the pipeline — foundations building, a model in your portfolio, degree path clear.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **DEFEND YOUR ASSUMPTIONS.** ★